

5 Steps to Financial Freedom in Uniform.

The exact system I used to go from \$0 to \$750,000 net worth — on a normal military salary.

Joe Do

US Army Soldier · Founder, Soldier to Millionaire

I came to America from Vietnam with nothing. I worked three jobs.

I had \$20 in my pocket in Hawaii at age 30.

Eight years later — \$750,000 net worth. House paid off. Financially free.

This guide is the exact system that made it happen.

BEFORE YOU BEGIN

A Note From Joe

This is not theory. I applied every word of this between 2018 and 2025 and went from \$0 to \$750,000 in net worth — on a normal income, without shortcuts, without luck, and without a financial background.

The system works because it is simple enough to actually do. Five steps. In order. No detours. I have shared this with 27+ soldiers in my unit and watched it change their financial trajectory within months.

You do not need to be a financial expert. You do not need a high salary. You need discipline, a system, and someone willing to show you the path. That is what this guide is for.

I paid off my home in 2 years and 9 months. I saved 60% of my income. I invested every spare dollar into the S&P; 500 and never sold during a downturn. The results speak for themselves.



Read this guide once to understand the full system. Then go back to Step 1 and start. The only wrong move is waiting.

— **Joe Do, US Army**

01

STEP ONE Become Debt Free

Before you do anything else, eliminate your debt. Debt is a guaranteed negative return. If you are paying 20% interest on a credit card, that is the same as losing 20% on every dollar you hold — no investment in the world reliably beats that.

List every debt you have — credit cards, car loans, personal loans, student loans. Order them from highest interest rate to lowest. Attack the highest rate first while making minimum payments on the rest. Every dollar you free up goes to the next debt on the list. This is called the avalanche method, and it is the mathematically optimal approach.

The one exception: if your employer offers a retirement account match, always contribute enough to capture it — even while paying off debt. A 100% match is a guaranteed return that beats almost any interest rate. Outside of that, eliminate the debt first. Everything else waits.

■ No debt, no drag. Every dollar you earn works for you — not for your lender.

02 STEP TWO Save Aggressively — At Least 50% of Your Income

Once you are debt free, the mission shifts to saving as much as possible. I saved roughly 60% of my income. I lived well below my means and refused to let my lifestyle grow with my income. Every raise, every bonus, every extra dollar went into the system — not a bigger apartment or a newer car.

Most people budget their spending. I budgeted my saving. The moment my paycheck landed, I moved my savings target out first. Whatever was left was my spending allowance. I did not need willpower — the system made the decision automatically.

The military gives you a massive advantage: BAH covers housing, BAS covers food, and TRICARE covers healthcare. Civilians pay thousands per month for what you receive as part of service. Use that gap to build wealth faster than any civilian peer at the same income level.

■ **Target: Save at least 50% of take-home. Automate it before you can spend it.**

STEP THREE

03 Max Out Every Tax-Advantaged Account

Tax-advantaged accounts are the single most powerful legal tool available to build wealth. The government lets your money grow — and in some cases lets you contribute — without paying taxes. That difference, compounded over decades, is worth hundreds of thousands of dollars.

Fill them in this order: 1. TSP — contribute at least 5% to capture the full BRS employer match. 2. Roth IRA — max it every year (\$7,000 in 2025). If deployed to a combat zone, your tax-free pay can go in tax-free — one of the best opportunities in the tax code. 3. HSA — triple tax advantage: pre-tax contributions, tax-free growth, tax-free medical withdrawals. 4. 529 — if you have children, start funding it early. Compounding is time-dependent. 5. Max TSP — after the above, maximize to the IRS limit (\$23,500 in 2025).

Only after all tax-advantaged accounts are maxed should you invest in a taxable brokerage account.

■ **Order: Employer match → Roth IRA → HSA → 529 → Max TSP → Taxable brokerage.**

STEP FOUR

04 Invest Everything in S&P; 500 Index Funds — and Never Sell

I do not pick stocks. I do not time the market. I do not watch CNBC. I put every dollar into the C Fund (TSP) or a low-cost S&P; 500 index fund — VFIAX, FXAIX, or VOO — and I wait.

Why the S&P; 500? Because over any 20-year period in history, it has never lost money. The average annual return is approximately 10%. Compounding 10% over 20 to 30 years turns small, consistent contributions into life-changing wealth. \$500/month at 10% annual return for 25 years grows to \$598,000. You do not need to be a genius. You need to be consistent.

The enemy of investing is not a bear market — it is you selling during one. I lived through multiple downturns between 2018 and 2025 and never sold a single share. Every dip was a sale. The market always recovered. Boring on purpose. Relentless by design.

■ C Fund (TSP) + Roth IRA in VFIAX or VOO. Set it. Forget it. Never sell in panic.

05 STEP FIVE Buy a Home and Pay It Off Quickly

Once your investment accounts are funded and running, buy a home — and pay it off as fast as possible. This eliminates your largest monthly expense and positions you for a significant tax-free gain when you sell.

Under IRS Section 121, if you have lived in your home as your primary residence for at least two of the last five years, you can exclude up to \$250,000 of capital gains from federal taxes when you sell (\$500,000 if married filing jointly). That is a quarter of a million dollars, completely tax free.

I paid my home off in 2 years and 9 months — paying only \$13,500 in total interest, a fraction of what a 30-year mortgage would have cost. Use your VA loan benefit: zero down payment, no private mortgage insurance, and competitive interest rates. It is one of the best mortgage products available to anyone. Use it wisely.

■ Buy smart. Pay it off fast. Sell after 5 years. Keep up to \$250K tax free.

YOUR MISSION BRIEF

Quick-Action Checklist

Print this page. Check off each item. This is your minimum viable action plan.

STEP 1 — DEBT

- ☐ List all debts with interest rates
- ☐ Order from highest to lowest rate
- ☐ Set minimum payments on all but the top debt
- ☐ Direct every extra dollar to the highest-rate debt

STEP 2 — SAVINGS

- ☐ Calculate your current savings rate (savings / take-home)
- ☐ Set a savings target of at least 20% (work toward 50%)
- ☐ Automate the transfer — savings leave before you can spend them
- ☐ Cut one lifestyle expense this week

STEP 3 — TAX-ADVANTAGED ACCOUNTS

- ☐ Log into MyPay — set TSP to at least 5% (capture the full match)
- ☐ Open a Roth IRA if you do not have one (Fidelity or Vanguard)
- ☐ Automate monthly Roth IRA contributions
- ☐ Check if HSA is available through your plan

STEP 4 — INVESTING

- ☐ Select C Fund in TSP (S&P; 500 equivalent)
- ☐ Select VFIAX, FXAIX, or VOO in your Roth IRA
- ☐ Set contributions to automatic — do not touch them
- ☐ Commit: I will not sell during a market downturn

STEP 5 — HOME

- Check VA loan eligibility at [VA.gov](https://www.va.gov)
- Get pre-approved when you plan to stay 3+ years
- Make extra principal payments every month
- Target payoff in under 10 years

Want Joe to Build Your Personal Plan?

This guide gives you the system. A free 30-minute session with Joe gives you a plan built around your specific rank, pay, and goals.

No pitch. No upsell. Just clarity.

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